Part A argument analysis: cram sheet

Key ideas

1. **A2 and A3** carry 12 of the 15 points. Spend most of the time on connections and evidence.
2. A2: name the claims and explain how each leads to the next and to the thesis. Order is not connection.
3. A3: judge specific evidence for relevance and source credibility, from the passage only.
4. A1: every part of the thesis, including any qualification, in one or two sentences.
5. Complete sentences only. Ethos, pathos or logos labels are not evaluation.

A2: line of reasoning

6 points

Claim vs evidence	Claim: arguable statement ("how do you know?"). Evidence: what answers that question.
Major claims	The steps the thesis needs; remove one and the argument has a hole.
Connections	Name the real link: because, so, answers, narrows, requires. Order is not connection.
Pivots, qualifications	If present, say where the move happens, what changes and why it matters.
Close the chain	Last sentence ties the claims back to the thesis.

A3: evidence

6 points

Specific pieces	Name the evidence and the exact claim it supports.
Relevance	Same group, place, time and scope as the claim?
Credibility	Expertise, purpose, date in context, methods if given; missing details limit confidence, they don't prove a flaw.
Sufficiency, limits	One anecdote vs a pattern; correlation, self-report, a company grading itself.
Open with a judgment	Overall effectiveness first, matching the real strengths and limits; no forced balance.
Hard limit	Evaluating only sources, not their specific evidence, cannot score 6.

A1: main argument

3 points

Every part	Position, reason, action and actor, in one or two sentences.
Qualification	Keep "not a ban", "only if" and similar limits.
Actors	As specific as the author names them; no vague "people".
Topic only	Earns 1. Half the thesis earns about 2.

The timed write

about 30 min

min	do this
0 to 8	Read, mark T, C1, C2, E and the major move; star the strongest and weakest evidence.
8 to 10	A1: every part of the thesis.
10 to 19	A2: opening claims and support, the key shift, the conclusion.
19 to 28	A3: overall judgment first, then 2 or 3 pieces in depth (optional strategy).
28 to 30	Reread: complete sentences, nothing bulleted, no invented credentials.

Practice: 35 max; a first try may take 40 to 45. On the exam, extra minutes come out of Part B's 90.

Templates (adapt to the passage)

A1 The author argues that [main position] because [main reasons].

A2 Initially, the author establishes [claim] through [evidence/subclaim], which [purpose]. Later, the author shifts from [X] to [Y] to [explain connection]. Finally, [conclusion move] reinforces/qualifies [overall argument] through [support].

A3 [Specific evidence] supports [claim] because [relevant strength]. However, [specific limitation established by the passage] limits [what can reasonably be concluded], making it [qualified effectiveness judgment]. Use "however" only for a real limitation.

Scoring rules paraphrased from the College Board's 2026 AP Seminar end-of-course exam scoring guidelines; timing beyond 30 minutes is practice guidance, not an official allowance. Abbreviations: AP, Advanced Placement; A1 to A3, Part A questions 1 to 3; C1, C2, claim 1, claim 2; T, thesis; E, evidence.
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